THE GREAT LAKES

"Kobayashi Maru"

Written by

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ACT ONE

FADE IN:

EXT. STREET - MORNING

We come in on a cozy, middle-class family home in the suburbs of Sacramento, California. Nothing out of the ordinary here, except for maybe the BABY SQUIRREL on the front lawn, trying to get its head out of a pack of CAMEL LIGHTS.

INT. LAKE KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

MAX LAKE, 13, sits at the kitchen table, scribbling into a notebook. He's not a bad-looking kid, but the words "hip" or "cool" would not come to mind.

His mother, LILA LAKE, 30s, enters. In her case, the words "Hot Mom" definitely apply.

LILA
Mmm. Smells like someone made a pot of coffee.

MAX
(not looking up)
And drank it. If you're making more, black, six sugars.

LILA
Max!

MAX
Sorry. Black, six sugars, *please*.

LILA
That's better. So when did you--

MAX
Can't really talk right now, Mom. Got a paper due in--
(glancing at his watch)
Crap, forty-seven minutes. How's that coffee coming?

LILA
Really, Max? We talked about this.

MAX
We talk about a lot of stuff, Mom. It's a little egotistical of you to expect me to remember everything.

She comes over, glancing down at his work.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

LILA
(reading)
"The Industrial Revolution began with the rise of the machines in 2029, and ended with the final battle of mankind versus Skynet in Terminator Salvation." Seriously?

MAX
I've already been stuffed in every trash can at school. The last thing I need is another A.

LILA
I'm warning you, mister - if I get called in for another stupid parent-teacher meeting, the violin lessons are back on.

MAX
I *liked* taking the violin. You're the one who said it made me look like a - what was your word? Weenie?

LILA
I never said that.

MAX
It was at a recital. We have it on video.

LILA
In that case, I meant it lovingly.

MAX
Besides, this is for Mr. Etheridge's class. The guy you flirted with in carpool line?

LILA
I wasn't flirting with him.

MAX
You wrote your phone number on his hand and circled it with a heart. The only thing you left out was "come and get it."

LILA
It wasn't a heart, Mr. Smarty-Pants. It was a smiley face. It's hard to draw accurately in lipstick.
(then)
You know, you should be thankful.
(MORE)

LILA (CONT'D)
Some parents are too wrapped up in their own lives to even care about their kids.
(then)
Did he say anything about me?

MAX
Let me think - nope.

LILA
Weenie.

She goes to the cabinet and takes down a box of cereal.

MAX
If you're looking for your cigarettes, I threw them away.

LILA
I don't know what you're talking about. You know I quit smoking.

MAX
Then I guess the Camel Lights are Trix's way of saying they're not just for kids anymore.

Lila, annoyed, puts the cereal box back on the shelf. She turns and opens the lid on the trash can.

LILA
Doesn't anyone around here take out the garbage anymore?

Yanking out the half-empty trash bag, she heads for the door.

MAX
I threw out the ones in the bird-feeder, too.

She quickly about-faces, dumping the bag back in the can.

LILA
You can find those but lose six retainers a year? Unbelievable.

MAX
(writing)
What's better - armageddon or apocalypse?

LILA
I'll take either one. Single mom, crap-paying job, and I can't even get a pathetic twerp of a teacher interested in me. Yeah, I'm ready for the end times.

VIOLET LAKE, 9, enters the kitchen. She's cute as a button, but *strange strange strange.*

VIOLET
(upset)
Mo-om! Look what Max did to Marlalala!

She holds up a BARBIE DOLL. Lila takes it and turns to Max.

LILA
Max, what did I tell you about Violet's dolls?

MAX
To stop putting their heads back on.

LILA
Thank you.

She snaps the doll's head off and hands it back to Violet.

LILA (CONT'D)
(to Max)
Now tell Marlala--

VIOLET
Marlalala.

LILA
--Tell the damn doll you're sorry.

MAX
Which part do I say it to?

LILA
I don't care. Just do it, or the violin lessons are off. Or on. Whichever one you didn't want.

Max unhappily turns to Violet, who holds out the doll.

MAX
I didn't mean anything. It's just that you're spooky and weird, and you really scare me sometimes.

VIOLET
You're scared of Marlalala?

MAX
I wasn't talking to the doll.

LILA
(warning)
Max...

MAX
Fine.
(to the doll)
I'm sorry for trying to re-capitate you. It was thoughtless and cruel.

Violet holds the doll's head-hole to her ear.

VIOLET
She forgives you. This time.
(then, cheerfully)
What's for breakfast?

SFX: THE DOORBELL RINGS.

LILA
(rising)
The kitchen outlet's still on the fritz, and the electrician couldn't come before this afternoon. How about some delicious frozen waffles?

VIOLET
Yay!

Lila crosses into the

LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Heading for the front door. She picks up and sniffs stray clothing as she goes, putting the clean on one shoulder, dirty on the other.

SFX: THE DOORBELL RINGS AGAIN. AND AGAIN.

LILA
Alright already! I'm coming! If this is another pair of Mormons, I'm gonna slash your damn bicycle tires--

She opens the front door. Standing there is GORDON LAKE, 40ish, her older brother. Decent-looking, he's a cheerfully disagreeable sort, the kind of guy some might call a jerk. Others would say asshole.

GORDON
Lila!

By the look on her face, Lila's clearly in the latter camp. Getting no response, Gordon gives it another go.

GORDON (CONT'D)
Lila!

LILA
(flatly)
I heard you the first time. What are you doing here, Gordon?

GORDON
Your brother stops by for a visit, and that's the reception he gets? How about a little enthusiasm? A little warmth?
(then, hopeful)
And maybe a little French toast?

LILA
I'm sorry, but you can't just show up at my door after two years and expect me to be all smiles and--

Violet comes in from the other room.

LILA (CONT'D)
(suddenly all smiles)
Look who's here!

VIOLET
Uncle Gordon!

GORDON
Hey there! It's... it's...

He looks to Lila for some help.

LILA
(coughing)
Violet.

GORDON
Violet!
(then, to Lila)
Really? That doesn't even ring a bell.

Violet runs over and hugs him. Max comes in, too.

GORDON (CONT'D)
And the other one...!

Lila coughs again.

GORDON (CONT'D)
What? Cough? Cough-ie?

LILA
I was actually coughing that time.

MAX
It's Max.

GORDON
Now that sounds like it could be right.

Gordon looks at the kids for long beat of awkward silence.

LILA
Well, this was nice, wasn't it? Max, I think you have a paper to fail, and Violet's waffle is defrosting, so...

Max and Lila exit. Gordon turns back to Lila.

GORDON
Good kids. You're obviously doing a great job at--

LILA
Yeah, yeah. You don't have a cigarette, do you?

GORDON
No... But your son's a teenager. Did you look under his mattress?

LILA
(glumly)
Yeah. Just maps of the moon. I didn't want to ask.

GORDON
Huh. I pegged the girl as the creepy one.

CUT TO:

INT. LAKE LIVING ROOM - A LITTLE LATER

The kids have left for school. Gordon sits on the couch as Lila, bent over by the fireplace, looks up the chimney.

LILA
Son of a-- The kid's gotta have freaking x-ray vision or something.

CONTINUED:

GORDON
You were always awful at hiding things. Remember when Mom found your birth control pills in the dog food?

LILA
She didn't find them - you told her where they were. Same as my pot stash. You got a car for that one.

GORDON
Which I let you borrow, right?

LILA
Big whoop. What good is a car to a teenager if she doesn't have pot or the pill?

GORDON
Now there's the Lila I remember.

Lila sighs and sits down.

LILA
So why are you really here? What do you want?

GORDON
Do I have to want something? Couldn't it be possible that I just came to visit my little sister, and Max, and...

LILA
Violet.

GORDON
That can't be right.

LILA
Gordon, we both know you've never given a second thought to anyone besides yourself in your entire life.

GORDON
I won't deny it. Mistakes were made by everyone.

LILA
So you're here to apologize?

GORDON
I thought I just did.
(then, off her look)
(MORE)

GORDON (CONT'D)
Fine, I'm sorry. And I'm here to make amends.

Lila studies him for a beat.

LILA
You're broke again, aren't you?

GORDON
Really, really sorry.

LILA
Oh God. And you need a place to live.

GORDON
(quickly)
Just temporarily. Only until I get reestablished.

LILA
Re-established? When were you ever e-stablished? Your acting career was a total bust.

GORDON
That was always just a stepping stone to bigger things. Corporate sponsorships, celebrity endorsements, social media influencer...

LILA
Right, didn't I just see you in a commercial for that herbal viagra that made animals attack the people who took it?

GORDON
Not all animals. Just birds.
(then)
Fame is my destiny, Lila. I can't fight it. I've been given a gift, and it would be selfish not to share it with the world. So I'm back in town where it all started - big fish, tiny pond - ready to turn things around. All I need is a home base to get things going again.

Lila thinks for a moment, then sighs.

LILA
Alright, the truth is, I could use a little help myself.
(MORE)

CONTINUED: (3)

LILA (CONT'D)
Ever since Steve ran off to “fulfill his destiny” as an Ice Road Trucker--

GORDON
Oh, great - you have cable.
(then, off her look)
Sorry, you were saying?

LILA
I was saying I have my hands pretty full around here. If you’re willing to help out with the kids, picking them up from school, getting them to doctors appointments, that kind of stuff... I guess you could sleep in Max’s room with him for a while.

GORDON
Done!

LILA
But one screw-up, Gordon, and I mean one tiny little screw-up, and you’re gone. Got it?

GORDON
Hug?

LILA
I’m good.

GORDON
Even better!

Gordon leaps up and opens the front door. MAGGIE DOOLITTLE, late 20s, a cheerful, mousy ball of nervous energy, enters, lugging his stuff.

GORDON (CONT'D)
You remember Maggie, my personal assistant? Who should be lifting with the knees, not the back.

MAGGIE
Hi, Lila! Wow, you look fantastic. Did you lose some weight, or--

GORDON
Don’t waste it. She already said yes.

LILA
(to Gordon)
You made her wait in the car for the last hour?

MAGGIE
No biggie. I spend most of my time in the car anyways. Actually, pretty much all of it.

LILA
You live in your car?

MAGGIE
It's not as bad as it sounds. You know how when you leave somewhere, and you've got a really long drive home? That never happens to me. I mean, sure, the 'Housies' look down at you, and yell at you to get the hell off their street, but that's mostly out of jealousy. And using their garden hose for doing dishes.

GORDON
Less chit-chat, Maggie, more hustle. What do you think I'm not paying you for?

MAGGIE
(to Lila)
He talks tough, but he's really an old softie. He just stole me a handicap placard for my birthday - and he had no idea about the new heart murmur.

LILA
(glances at her watch)
I have to get to work. When you're done snooping around the house, there's some waffles in the freezer. Just stay out of the drawer next to my bed, okay?

GORDON
Fair enough.

CUT TO:

INT. LILA'S BEDROOM - A LITTLE LATER

Gordon stands by Lila's bed, a look of mild disgust on his face as he stares down at the open drawer. Maggie, peering down over his shoulder, just looks confused.

GORDON
Why don't I ever listen to people?

MAGGIE
Are those regulation size?

CONTINUED:

She starts to reach in, and Gordon slaps her hand.

FADE OUT:

END OF ACT ONE

ACT TWO

FADE IN:

EXT. CITY STREET - DAY

Gordon and Maggie, in her JUNK-FILLED CAR, pull up in front of some shops. Gordon peers unhappily out the window.

GORDON
God, just looking at the place makes my skin crawl.

MAGGIE
That might be the car. I've been having some flea problems since the stay near that dog park.
(then)
Are you sure you want to do this?

GORDON
It's all part of the master plan. A, excite the fan base; Two, generate buzz; C, word spreads. Gordon Lake is back in town, and everyone wants him. It's only a matter of time before they're banging down my door again. Only this time, it's for good things.

MAGGIE
You're the smartest man I ever met. And I dated my high school math teacher.

Gordon gets out of the car.

CUT TO:

INT. COMIC BOOK SHOP - CONTINUOUS

A few NERDS stand around, reading comics. A few others sit at a card table playing MAGIC: THE GATHERING.

Gordon steps into the doorway, and all the chatter stops. Like in a bad Western, everyone watches in silence as Gordon slowly approaches WAYNE, the shop owner, at the counter.

WAYNE
Well, well. Look what the Kraken dragged in.

GORDON
Hello, Wayne. Good news. I'm here to take you up on your offer.

CONTINUED:

Wayne laughs mockingly.

WAYNE
That offer was made a long time ago, in a galaxy far, far away. No one even remembers you anymore, Lake. You're obsolete. A pog. Hayden Christensen. You're Yahoo Chat, and you don't even know it.

GORDON
Am I?
(turning to the nerds)
Which one of you losers wants to show off?

NERD #1
(quickly)
Gordon Lake, AKA Jovor, the Vulcan psychologist on TNG, '93-'94 season.

NERD #2
Notable episodes - "Warf's Revenge" and "Data Goes A'Courtin'"--

NERD #1
--in which his character was beaten to death by a pack of drunken Farengis.

Gordon cockily turns back to Wayne.

GORDON
Sounds like I'm a little less JLo and a little more JLaw.

WAYNE
(sighs)
Frack. Okay, we'll do it. But the terms remain the same as last time. You have to wear the costume.

GORDON
(vehemently)
Not a chance! I swore that I'd never subject myself to that kind of humiliation again. There is no way--
(giving up quickly)
Ah, I don't have the energy for this. What time should I be here?

CUT TO:

EXT. STREET - MOMENTS LATER

Gordon comes out of the shop to find Maggie waiting on the sidewalk, hefting a TIRE IRON.

MAGGIE
Everything okay? I was just about to come in and tune up some dorks.

GORDON
Everything's fine. It's on.

MAGGIE
Still, it never hurts to send a message.

GORDON
Stand down, Mags. We have to go pick up the kids.

MAGGIE
Wow, you remembered. I'm impressed. "Thinking of others" isn't generally your thing.

GORDON
I forgot you at the airport once.

MAGGIE
Three times.

GORDON
Are we going to stand here and nit-pick, or are we getting the kids?

MAGGIE
Okay, but we should probably wait a bit. I just flea-bombed.

Gordon looks over at her car - it's CLOUDED WITH GAS.

CUT TO:

INT. LAKE KITCHEN - AFTERNOON

Lila stands at the counter as SAL, a BURLY ELECTRICIAN, studies the broken outlet. Lila notices his neck and head are covered with BAND-AIDS.

LILA
What's with all the band-aids?

CONTINUED:

SAL
Weirdest thing. I came out of my house yesterday, and I was dive-bombed by a bunch of pigeons.

LILA
Huh. That is weird.

She glances over at a box of Gordon's stuff on the table. His face grins back at her from a BOTTLE OF HERBAL VIAGRA.

LILA (CONT'D)
So? What's the damage?

SAL
Mostly cosmetic, but the dermatologist said if I put on this ointment--

LILA
I meant the outlet.

SAL
Oh. You need a new conductor and contact plate. With labor, it'll run you about a hundred fifty.

LILA
What?! Are you--

She catches herself, and shifts into flirty mode.

LILA (CONT'D)
Oh my, such complicated words. And me, just a simple, helpless woman, living here all by my lonesome.

Spotting Marlalala on the counter, she grabs it and hides it behind her back.

LILA (CONT'D)
I'm sure a smart, manly fella like you can understand that.

She smiles and bats her eyes. It's not pretty.

SAL
(unimpressed)
Look, I'm sure you're a nice lady and all, but it's still a hundred and fifty bucks.

LILA
(blowing up)
For a job any monkey with a screwdriver can do?! Forget it!

Sal shrugs, and starts packing up his tools.

LILA (CONT'D)
You think because I'm a woman you can take advantage of me? I have a Masters in English lit! It's useless, but it's true!

Sal heads for the door.

LILA (CONT'D)
(calling after him)
And by the way, Romeo, I know why birds attack you!

CUT TO:

EXT. SCHOOL CAMPUS - AFTERNOON

Max trails alongside a GROUP OF POPULAR KIDS.

DEVON
Are you guys going to Ashley's party Friday night?

KAITLIN
Probably. Everyone's going. Even if her mom's a MILF with way too much FOMO.

HILLARY
OMG, Kaitlin! SMH. But I totes agree.

MAX
(piping in)
Yeah, totes.

The group stops, noticing Max for the first time.

KAITLIN
Um, who are you again?

MAX
Max.
(off her blank look)
Max Lake? You copy off me in Social Studies. We were in the same carpool for two years.

CONTINUED:

KAITLIN
Oh. Right.
(a beat, then)
Hi.

MAX
So Ashley's having a party on Friday?

KAITLIN
(glancing at the others)
Kind of... but nobody's really going.

MAX
(covering)
Oh yeah, I wasn't-- I mean, who would want to, with a foamy milk mom like hers, right?

Silent stares.

MAX (CONT'D)
Lol?

More silence. Max, giving up, slinks away and angrily walks over to Gordon, who's been watching from the sidewalk.

GORDON
(cheerfully)
Hmm. Not exactly Mr. Popular, are we?

MAX
I don't want to talk about it.

GORDON
I wouldn't either. You really went down in flames there.

MAX
Thanks, I didn't notice. Can we go now?

They head for Maggie's car, parked at the curb.

GORDON
It's a good thing we picked up your sister first. You don't get to see something like that every day.

They get into the car. Max glances over at the UNHAPPY-LOOKING NINE-YEAR-OLD GIRL next to him in the back seat.

MAX
This isn't Violet.

Gordon and Maggie turn in their seats to study the girl.

CONTINUED: (2)

GORDON
What? Are you sure?

WRONG VIOLET
I told you, mister.

GORDON
Thank you. Nobody likes a know-it-all.

Off Gordon's worried look, we...

FADE OUT:

END OF ACT TWO

ACT THREE

FADE IN:

INT. LAKE KITCHEN - EVENING

Gordon, Maggie, Max, and Violet sit at the table.

MAGGIE
Wow. Really not used to eating dinner without a steering wheel in front of me. I can't remember the last time I cut my meat without the horn honking.

VIOLET
You're funny. Are you our aunt now?

MAGGIE
(laughing)
Oh, no, don't be silly.
(then, whispering)
Not yet.

Lila sets down a plate of UNCOOKED HOT DOGS in front of them.

MAX
Cold hot dogs?

VIOLET/MAGGIE
Yay!

LILA
(annoyed)
How was I supposed to know electricians are so touchy? And loyal. You insult one of them, and no one else will even answer your damn phone call.

GORDON
This is your prom date all over again, isn't it?

LILA
What's that supposed to mean?

GORDON
It means you've always had problems dealing with people, Lila. You alienate them without even knowing it.

CONTINUED:

LILA
What are you talking about?! Rodrigo stood me up on prom night because you paid him to stand in line for Hootie and the Blowfish tickets!

GORDON
A simple scheduling mistake. Although I did wonder why he wore a tuxedo. My point is, if you just stopped to listen to someone else for a minute, maybe you wouldn't find yourself in unnecessary messes that--

VIOLET
(brightly)
I got to sit in a police car today.

LILA
A police car? Why were you--

Maggie quickly takes a bite of hot dog.

MAGGIE
Mmmm! Are these all-beef? I feel like the queen of England here!

Lila looks at her cell phone.

LILA
Why did the school call four times? Gordon? What happened? We talked about this.

GORDON
We talk about a lot of things, Lila. It's pretty selfish to expect me to remember everything.

Max looks over at Gordon, surprised to hear almost the exact same words coming from him that he used that morning.

LILA
(pointedly)
Gordon?

Gordon sighs - *he's busted*.

GORDON
Okay, now if you keep a really open mind here you might find this as funny as I did--

MAX
(stepping in)
The reason the school called was to remind you about the assembly tomorrow. Mr. Etheridge asked specifically if you were coming.

LILA
He did?
(then, smiling to herself)
I knew that weenie would come around.

Gordon looks thankfully to Max, who purposely ignores him. Maggie puts a second hot dog on her plate.

CUT TO:

INT. MAX'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

Max sits at his desk, on his laptop computer, as Gordon flops around on a fold-away cot. He rolls over and looks at Max.

GORDON
Just out of curiosity - why did you do save me in there?

MAX
I'm not sure. I guess for the same reason I keep putting the heads back on Violet's dolls. I have a soft spot for broken things.

GORDON
(considers)
That makes some sense, in a pretty insulting way.

He rolls back over. After a beat, Max turns to him.

MAX
Can I ask you something? Say, hypothetically, I wanted to be more popular at school. What could I do? Everything I try just makes things worse.

GORDON
(thoughtfully)
Ah. The *Kobayashi Maru*.

MAX
The what?

GORDON
Kobayashi Maru. It's the no-win scenario Captain Kirk faced as a cadet at Star Fleet Academy. All the possible options lead to failure.

MAX
Yeah, that pretty much sums up high school. So what did he do?

GORDON
He realized that when facing an impossible situation, the only way to win was to change the rules.

MAX
Change the rules, huh? I never thought of that. I guess it's worth a try, right? I mean, what's the worst that can happen? The janitor won't eat lunch with me anymore?

GORDON
You eat lunch with the janitor?

MAX
Well, I eat. He mostly just drinks and sharpens things.

CUT TO:

INT. KITCHEN - MIDNIGHT

Gordon shuffles into the darkened kitchen, on the phone.

GORDON
(into phone)
Go to sleep, Maggie. The scratching is probably just raccoons. If they manage to get in, just honk.

He hangs up and opens the refrigerator. He sees a CHOCOLATE CAKE inside, with a note that reads "DO NOT EAT - FOR VIOLET'S CLASS PARTY".

He happily takes out the cake and grabs a fork. Turning, he jumps as he sees Violet, sitting at the table, lit by moonlight, having a tea party with a bunch of her headless dolls.

GORDON (CONT'D)
Gahhh!

He quickly hides the cake behind his back.

CONTINUED:

VIOLET
Hi, Uncle Gordon. Want to join us for tea? You can sit next to Shirley. Just be careful - the moon makes her stabby.

GORDON
Umm, no thanks. I just came in here to... to...

VIOLET
Fix the plug?

GORDON
Exactly! To fix the plug.
(turning to the outlet)
Your mother asked me to help around the house, and that’s what I’m doing.

He prods at the outlet with the fork.

GORDON (CONT'D)
So feel free to tell her you saw me, you know, helping out.

He pokes at it again, and a SMALL FLAME SUDDENLY SHOOTS OUT. Gordon slaps at it with an OVEN MITT, WHICH ALSO BURSTS INTO FLAME. As he throws it in the sink, he turns back to Violet.

GORDON (CONT'D)
On second thought, let’s keep it our little secret.

VIOLET
Okay.

Gordon sighs, relieved. A CAR HORN outside starts honking.

FADE OUT:

END OF ACT THREE

ACT FOUR

FADE IN:

INT. LAKE KITCHEN - DAY

Lila is in the kitchen with Sal, who stands at the counter, wolfing down a piece of the chocolate cake.

LILA
Thanks for coming back. A lot of people don't understand Tourette's Syndrome, and--

SAL
(mouth full)
Mm hmm, whatever. This is good cake. Can I take some home for my kids?

LILA
Oh, come on--
(catching herself)
I mean, sure, absolutely. I probably have some dried apricots I can send for Violet's class party.

Sal unscrews the outlet plate and takes a look inside.

LILA (CONT'D)
So, like I was saying, a hundred and fifty dollars sounds more than fair...

SAL
Actually, it's gonna be more like three hundred. Look at that - some clown completely fried the wiring.

LILA
What?! Three hund--

GORDON (O.S.)
Who are you calling a clown?

They both turn to see Gordon standing in the doorway. He looks utterly ridiculous in POINTY VULCAN EARS AND A SPARKLY TUNIC. A GIANT CHEESY MEDALLION hangs from his neck.

LILA
Gordon, don't - please.

GORDON
Let me handle this, Lila. I'm here to help, right?
(then, to Sal)
(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

GORDON (CONT'D)
So you're the big man who thinks it's okay to take advantage of a lonely, simple-minded woman, and eat an innocent little girl's cake?

LILA
I'm not lonely!

GORDON
(ignoring her)
You think you're pretty clever because you have a tool belt and some band aids on your head, don't you? Well, for your information, no one's impressed. Do you understand what I'm telling you? You're a buffoon. A laughingstock. You're the clown, and you're too thick-headed to even know it.

Maggie comes into the kitchen.

MAGGIE
You forgot your shoes.

She hands Gordon a pair of GLITTERY SHOES WITH BELLS ON THE CURLED TOES.

GORDON
We're late. I'll put them on in the car.

Gordon and Maggie hustle out. Lila glares after him.

LILA
Son of a--

She sees Sal packing up his stuff.

LILA (CONT'D)
No, please - don't go! Tourette's runs in families! Everyone knows that! My uncle once called Ellen DeGeneres a sea cow! Live on the air!

Ignoring her, he heads for the door. Lila lets out a frustrated sigh.

LILA (CONT'D)
Great. Now I have to bake another stupid cake.

CUT TO:

EXT. COMIC BOOK SHOP - AFTERNOON

A surprising number of FANS, some in costume, wait outside. A sign in the window reads “JOVOR AUTOGRAPH SIGNING TODAY”.

INT. SHOP - CONTINUOUS

Gordon, in costume, sits at a folding card table. Maggie stands beside him, hefting the tire iron in her hands.

MAGGIE
Just say the word if anyone gets too handsy.

GORDON
How many Red Bulls have you had today?
(then)
Never mind. Are my ears on straight?

Wayne comes over.

WAYNE
We actually have a pretty good turn-out out there. I hate to say it, Jovor, but this could go well for you.

Gordon’s cellphone rings. He answers.

GORDON
Hello?

INTERCUT WITH:

INT. SCHOOL HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

Max, on his cellphone, holding a VIOLIN CASE.

MAX
(excited)
I did it! I did what you said.

GORDON
See? I told you.
(then)
Who is this, and what did I say?

MAX
It’s Max. I took your advice and volunteered my string trio to play before the school assembly today.

GORDON
(alarmed)
I’m pretty sure I didn’t say that.
(MORE)

CONTINUED:

GORDON (CONT'D)
I've never used the word trio in my life. Threesome, yes, trio, no.

MAX
You said to change the rules, and that's what I did. I had to get people to notice me, and the violin's the only thing I'm any good at.

GORDON
Listen to me - you can't do this. It doesn't matter how good you are at the violin. Pete Townsend was the best violin player in England, and he was chased home from school every day by Roger Daltrey and the other popular kids. Where do you think he learned to smash his guitars? From destroying the violin that ruined his life, that's where!

MAX
You just made all that up.

GORDON
Possibly, but that's not the point. What I'm saying is, rock stars get the girls, and the fame, and all the glory. Violinists get nothing - if they're lucky. Don't do this, Max.

MAX
It's too late. I can't back out now.

Max hangs up.

MAX (CONT'D)
(to himself, grimly)
Kobayashi Maru.

Gordon hangs up as well, looking worried.

GORDON
(to himself, grimly)
Kobayashi Maru.

WAYNE
All right, Jovor. We're opening the doors. Push the Suicide Squad stuff - I can't get rid of that crap.

Gordon wrestles with himself for a beat, then stands up.

GORDON
I have to go.

WAYNE
Go? Are you out of your Vulcan mind? You can't leave now! You're walking away from close to a hundred dollars. And a possible comeback. Isn't that everything you wanted?

Gordon thinks for a beat, taking this in. Then:

GORDON
I thought so.

MAGGIE
(to Gordon, worried)
What's wrong?

GORDON
Max needs me.

WAYNE
I'm warning you, Jovor - they'll rip you to shreds out there. Some of those people have been waiting almost half an hour!

Gordon, ignoring him, heads for the door, his shoes tinkling as he walks.

MAGGIE
(in awe)
There goes my hero.

CUT TO:

EXT. SHOP - MOMENTS LATER

Maggie, swinging the tire iron, clears a path for Gordon through the angry crowd as they head for her car.

MAGGIE
Get back, nerds! Get back or I'm boldly going upside your geek skulls!

CUT TO:

INT. SCHOOL AUDITORIUM - CONTINUOUS

The room is packed with parents and students. Lila, in the audience, spots a young teacher - his name tag reads MR. ETHERIDGE - and gives him a flirty wave. He waves back, unsure.

On stage, the PRINCIPAL, steps up to the microphone.

PRINCIPAL
Before we begin today, three of our students have volunteered to entertain us with a piece of classical music. Ladies and gentlemen, I very hesitantly give you... The Wild Strings!

Lila, in her seat, shakes her head in amusement.

LILA
Weenies.

Max, with his VIOLIN, and two other kids with a VIOLA and CELLO, step onto the stage. Lila reacts.

LILA (CONT'D)
Oh God. That's my weenie.

Gordon, still in costume, rushes in. He glances around, and spots what he's looking for - a FIRE ALARM on a nearby wall.

He dashes over and pulls the lever. The entire FIRE ALARM SNAPS OFF IN HIS HAND - it has been DUCT-TAPED TO THE WALL.

He makes eye contact with Max on stage. He shakes his head at him - *don't do it!* Max turns away.

The trio starts playing Mozart's DIVERTIMENTO IN E-FLAT. The kids in the audience begin to snicker. As the laughter grows, Lila sinks lower and lower into her seat.

Max suddenly goes off-book, CHANGING FROM THE CLASSICAL PIECE TO THE WHO'S "TEENAGE WASTELAND". The other two kids stop playing, confused, as Max proceeds to wobble through the song by himself.

The audience, too, quiets down, watching in silence as Max CAREENS AND STRUTS AROUND THE STAGE A LA PETE TOWNSEND. He's not particularly good, but he sure has his heart in it.

Finishing the song, he raises the violin over his head and SMASHES IT TO SMITHEREENS ON THE FLOOR. HE THEN GRABS THE OTHER KID'S VIOLA AND VIOLENTLY SWINGS IT AT THE CELLO, DESTROYING THEM AS WELL.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

He finally stops, exhausted, and stares out at the silent audience. Lila and Gordon stare, stunned. The JANITOR, standing at the back of the auditorium, shakes his head in disgust.

JANITOR
No more drinking with that kid.

CUT TO:

INT. SCHOOL HALLWAY - A LITTLE LATER

Max stands alone. A bunch of kids, including Devon, Kaitlin and Hillary, stand nearby, looking at him like he's some kind of freak.

Lila and Gordon approach.

LILA
(to Max)
That's it, mister! You've finally gone too far!

GORDON
Go easy on him, Lila. This was actually my faul--

LILA
No! This behavior has got to stop. Hiding your cigarettes around the house, turning my favorite vase into a bong, taking the car for illegal joyrides...

MAX
(confused)
But I didn't--

The looks on the other kids' faces slowly change from mockery to admiration. Gordon picks up on what's going on.

GORDON
Your mother's right. And she didn't mention the fake ID, or the constant parade of girls sneaking into your room after curfew.

LILA
(aside, to Gordon)
Let's keep it believable.

GORDON
Got it.
(then, to Max)
(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

GORDON (CONT'D)
So clean up your act, buster, because none of these teenagers want to be friends with a wild and mysterious rebel. Understand?

Max glances over at the other kids, who are staring in astonished awe.

MAX
(faux rebellious)
Fine.

Gordon and Lila start to head out. They glance back to see Max surrounded by the other kids. He mouths “thank you” to them.

GORDON
Not bad.

LILA
Yeah, we were actually a pretty good team there.
(then)
Still, two weeks suspension, three thousand dollars in damage, and there’s no way Mr. Etheridge is ever calling now.

GORDON
Does that mean you want me to go?

Lila stops, thinking.

LILA
(grimly)
Kobayashi Maru.

GORDON
(happily)
I’ll take that as a no.

Maggie approaches.

MAGGIE
Wow. I don’t know about you guys, but that was the most amazing concert I’ve ever--

GORDON
Don’t waste it, Maggie. We’re still in!
(then)
(MORE)

GORDON (CONT'D)
We may have burned our bridge with Wayne, so we have to start brainstorming our next move. Local radio host? Maybe a daytime talk show--

LILA
You can stop right there. I know exactly what you're doing next.

CUT TO:

INT. LAKE KITCHEN - EVENING

Lila, Max, Violet and Maggie sit at the table, happily eating take-out Chinese food.

LILA
This is delicious, Maggie. Where did you find this restaurant?

MAGGIE
I park behind it sometimes, and the smell coming out of their dumpster was just mouth-watering.

Violet shoves an eggroll down Marlalala's head-hole. Max, his laptop open in front of him, smiles happily.

MAX
This is awesome! I've been 'Friended' by half the school, and even got invited to Ashley's party! I'm probably not gonna go, cuz her mom's such a foamy milk, but still!

LILA
(confused)
Foamy milk?

VIOLET
(still feeding her doll)
He means FOMO MILF.

MAX
Whatever. Thanks again, mom. You too, Uncle Gordon.

SFX: ELECTRIC ZAPPING SOUND

GORDON (O.S.)
Gahhh!

A sweaty Gordon, standing by the outlet, drops a screwdriver. A book on ELECTRIC REPAIR is open in front of him.

CONTINUED:

GORDON (CONT'D)
(shaking his hand in pain)
You're welcome.

LILA
How's it coming over there?

GORDON
I think I just about got it.

He picks up the screwdriver again and prods at a loose wire.

SFX: ANOTHER ZAP

GORDON (CONT'D)
Gahhhhh!

LILA
Let us know. You still have a cake to bake.

As they continue eating, we...

CUT TO:

EXT. HOUSE - CONTINUOUS

The baby squirrel sits on the front lawn, its head still stuck in a cigarette pack. As we pull away...

SFX: A LOUDER ZAP

The lights in the windows dim and flicker.

GORDON (O.S.)
Gahhhhhhhh!
(then)
Is it just me, or does it suddenly smell blurry in here?

FADE TO BLACK.

END OF SHOW